

Prior Art
For The
Lost & Found Item Tracker

Group 8

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1. Snapchat Community Story

1.1 Snapchat Lost and Found Functionality

Snapchat is a multimedia messaging application that allows users to send photos, videos, and messages that disappear after being viewed or after a short duration, typically 24 hours after the initial posting. One common use of the platform within local or university communities has been for lost and found purposes, facilitated through the Snapchat Community Story feature. This functionality allows users that share a campus to post temporary stories viewable by other users, enabling others to see lost or found items in their vicinity.

The process is informal and user-driven: individuals who discover an item can upload an image and an optional short description to their story, while others who recognize the item are able to contact them through Snapchat's direct messaging system. The platform's emphasis on visual content and its large user base make it an accessible method for spreading awareness quickly within local areas.

However, this approach is unstructured, temporary, and dependent on user visibility. This solution is further hindered when taking into account the various other uses for the community Snapchat story, which can result in "flooding" of the feed, making it harder for users to find lost items. Snapchat stories expire after 24 hours, and there is no centralized database or search functionality for locating specific posts once they are removed. As a result, while Snapchat serves as a convenient communication tool, it lacks the infrastructure necessary for a dedicated, reliable lost and found tracking system.

1.2 Comparison to the Proposed System

Our Lost and Found Tracker system builds upon the concept of community engagement seen in Snapchat but addresses its core limitations. The proposed system will provide a centralized and persistent database where lost and found items can be stored indefinitely until claimed or removed by an administrator. Users will be able to add, browse, and search posts using filters such as item type, date, and location.

The platform aims to maintain the open, user-focused spirit of Snapchat by allowing individuals to post and find items directly, without the need for heavy moderation. However, unlike Snapchat, the information will remain accessible until an item is claimed, ensuring that users can return later to check or update listings.

1.3 Summary of Key Differences

Feature	Snapchat Community Story	Proposed Lost and Found Tracker
Data Persistence	Temporary (24-hour expiration)	Persistent, until item is claimed or removed
Search and Filtering	None	Search and filter by category, date, or location
User Verification	None	User registration for contact consistency
Moderation	None	Minimal, focused on user autonomy
Accessibility	Requires Snapchat app and enrollment in university community story	Accessible via web or mobile browser
Intended Use	General social interaction	Dedicated lost and found tracking

2. UW-Milwaukee Lost & Found Services

2.1 University Services Functionality

For those on the university grounds, the UW-Milwaukee University Police offer a variety of services, one of which being a lost and found service. According to the University Police website, their lost and found service is for retrieving lost items of value that were turned in around campus and brought to the officers. People who are attempting to find their lost property are directed to either visit the police department or call their non-emergency phone number to retrieve their missing property.

The university also has mention of lost and found services being offered through the service desk in the Student Union, as well as the service desks at each of the residence halls for those living on campus. These locations each have their own phone number to communicate with to access the lost and found services; however, there is no indication on any of the sites that there is any cooperation or synergy between locations.

2.2 Comparison to Proposed System

Our Lost and Found Tracker system is intended to be designed with centralization intended. The services offered through the university do not seem to coordinate throughout the six different phone numbers and service desks being utilized. By being web-based, our system will centralize the lost item postings to make finding an item easier for the user. The proposed system would also allow the users trying to locate their lost items to be able to browse and search without having to physically travel to the locations to try and find their items. The proposed system also allows users who are

more averse to making phone calls to search for and coordinate the retrieval of their missing items nonverbally through the system.

2.3 Summary of Key Differences

Feature	University Services	Proposed Lost and Found Tracker
Data Persistence	Temporary (24-hour expiration)	Persistent, until item is claimed or removed
Search and Filtering	Physically going to service desk or calling related phone numbers	Search and filter by category, date, or location
User Verification	None	User registration for contact consistency
Moderation	None	Minimal, focused on user autonomy
Accessibility	Requires ability to physically travel to service desks or access to a phone	Accessible via web or mobile browser
Intended Use	General social interaction	Dedicated lost and found tracking

3. ReclaimDesk

3.1 ReclaimDesk Functionality

ReclaimDesk is a web-based lost and found system designed for use by large organizations like airports, hotels, and other public venues. The website provides a centralized system for tracking lost and found items, including many of the same features that we intend to implement in our Lost and Found Item Tracker system. It works as an extension of a traditional lost and found, allowing the organisation's staff to log found items with descriptions and pictures, allowing users who have misplaced items to search for their item on ReclaimDesks database. If a user finds their lost item on their website, they can then send a claim request online via email. At this point, if the claim request is accepted, the user is able to schedule a time to come and pick up their item from the organization using ReclaimDesks system.

3.2 Comparison to Proposed System

Our Lost and Found Tracker is similar to ReclaimDesk, but functions at a smaller community level rather than at an industry level. Some of the features that are the same between the two are the submission of found items, which include descriptions, photos, location, and date. Both also provide the ability to search for and claim lost items. The main difference between ReclaimDesk and our proposed Lost and Found Item Tracker is

the fact that ReclaimDesk relies on locations where lost items are taken and then uploaded to the website via the staff of the business using their subscription service, while our Lost and Found Item Tracker is designed so that found items can be uploaded by either users who come across lost items or staff at one of the many decentralized lost and found locations on the UWM campus effectively centralizing the campus lost and found. The key difference with our approach is the fact that when scheduling a pickup, it would not necessarily be directly through one of the campus lost and found locations, and may instead be carried out via both the user who found the item and the user who lost it.

3.3 Summary of Key Differences

Feature	University Services	Proposed Lost and Found Tracker
Data Persistence	Persistent, keeps past items in the database for audits	Persistent, until item is claimed or removed
Search and Filtering	Advanced search with keyword and category matching	Search and filter by category, date, or location
User Verification	User registration via email	User registration for contact consistency
Moderation	Staff managed	Minimal, focused on user autonomy
Accessibility	Subscription-based web application (free for users)	Accessible via web or mobile browser
Intended Use	Dedicated lost and found tracking	Dedicated lost and found tracking

4. Survey Methodology

The analysis of existing solutions was conducted through a focused review of social media systems, app-based systems, and local systems that facilitate community-driven lost and found exchanges. The primary goal of this survey was to identify commonly used tools and assess their functionality, accessibility, and effectiveness in supporting item recovery within a university setting.

4.1 Snapchat Community Story

Snapchat was identified as a relevant platform for comparison due to its widespread use among university students for informal lost and found communication. Users frequently post images or messages about lost items to community stories, making the information visible to nearby users.

This assessment was based on targeted search engine research as well as personal experience with how students at the University of Wisconsin-Milwaukee utilize the

platform. The findings revealed an opportunity for improvement through a dedicated lost and found system with persistent, searchable records.

Search Engines Accessed: Google, Bing

Keywords Used: “Snapchat lost and found,” “Snapchat story lost item,” “Snapchat community story UWM,” “Snapchat found item post,” “Snapchat campus lost and found”

4.2 University Lost & Found Services

Services offered by UW-Milwaukee were identified as a relevant platform for comparison due to it being a service offered to students and visitors to the university. Information for the assessment was obtained through search engine research as well as communication with UW-Milwaukee’s University Police.

University Police Contact: Sergeant Joseph Kelsey

Search Engines Accessed: Google

Keywords Used: “UW-Milwaukee lost and found”

4.3 ReclaimDesk

ReclaimDesk was identified as a relevant platform for comparison due to it being a large-scale corporate-level implementation of a centralized web-based lost and found item tracker. Information for the assessment was obtained via ReclaimDesks website.

Search Engines Accessed: Google

Keywords Used: “ReclaimDesk”

Citations

Mehr, J. (2024, January 10). Opinion: The university snapchat stories unify campus. The Review.

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